

Read: Luke 3:7-18

We Are Not Worthy

Luke 3:15-18

The people were waiting expectantly and were all wondering in their hearts if John might possibly be the Messiah. John answered them all, "I baptize you with water. But one who is more powerful than I will come, the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire. His winnowing fork is in his hand to clear his threshing floor and to gather the wheat into his barn, but he will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire." And with many other words John exhorted the people and proclaimed the good news to them.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

In an old movie, *Wayne's World* (you can ask your parents about it), the main characters bow down in front of a famous person and say, "We're not worthy! We're not worthy!" This person is so much more important and famous than they are, so when they find out who he is, they bow down to him.

In Luke 3, people start wondering if John the Baptist is the important and famous Messiah, the Savior, that God had promised would come for so long. In response, John bows down at the feet of the true Messiah and says, "I'm not worthy! I'm not worthy!" Jesus is so much more important and famous than John because he's more powerful than he is. John baptized people, but Jesus gave baptism its power. John told people about Jesus, but Jesus was the one who sent the Holy Spirit, so John and, eventually, the other disciples could talk about him.

John's response—like the response in that movie—is a good one. "We're not worthy! We're not worthy!" We can't come like the Pharisees did, thinking that they were so special that God had to let them into heaven. We're sinners that don't belong in heaven! We're not worthy to even bow at Jesus' feet! He is the perfect and powerful God. We're not worthy!

But Jesus is also the Messiah—the promised Savior. The proud Pharisees, and all of us with proud, sinful hearts, deserve to be cut down like dead trees and thrown into the fire. But the Savior came to save people who are not worthy enough to enter heaven. He did that by bowing down and being treated like an unworthy sinner in our place. He was like a tree cut down and thrown into the fire for us. Because of that, we are worthy in God's eyes.

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- What is the name of the group of people who thought they were better than Jesus?
- Who did people wrongly think was the Messiah?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Why did John say he is not worthy of Jesus? Why do we?
- Messiah basically means “chosen one.” What was Jesus chosen to do by the Father?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- In what ways can acknowledging our unworthiness help us appreciate Jesus?
- What can Christians say to friends who struggle with feelings of unworthiness?

Closing Prayer:

Dear Jesus, we are not worthy of all the mercies you show us. But you are a friend of sinners, and you let us live with you. Help us live in a way that says “thank you” for your mercy. Amen.